

inebriated Russian leader who opened up the system only to be gobbled up by the waves that accompanied the first flush of reforms. And like the late Russian leader, Vijayan faces the prospects of being judged not as one who attempted to reform the party, but as a symbol for the bad omens faced by the party. The cheerless dark lord who presides over CPI(M)'s contemporary ills—corruption, links with corporate mafia, repression of dissent, violence against political rivals, intolerance of critics—be it from the media, the judiciary or the intelligentsia.

All this was on display last fortnight when Vijayan used the might of the party organisation, which he virtually holds in an iron grip, to run down his bete noire, Chief Minister Achuthanandan. The skirmishes between the two had reached a new high, forcing even the party's central leadership to intervene. Prakash Karat flew down to Thiruvananthapuram.

The central leadership, caught between two realities—Vijayan's organisational strength and the unmatched popularity of Achuthanandan—yet again, failed to make any headway in its attempts to end the factional war. And with the party's local and district level meetings in September, to be followed by the state conference in February next year, it is clear that the rival camps are readying for a final showdown to capture the organisation. "This year we have issued special guidelines for the conduct of the meetings being held from lowest level—more than 20,000 local committees—to prevent a repeat of last time's factionalism. We will monitor that the guidelines are implemented strictly," said an exasperated Karat, who is forced to attend most of the state committee and secretariat meetings to prevent open clashes between the two camps.

Though the central leadership holds both Achuthanandan and Vijayan responsible for the deep divide in the party, recent incidents don't portray Vijayan in good light. Almost all party leaders who are in the dock for alleged irregularities owe allegiance to him. Achuthanandan came to acquire a folk hero's image among the people for his relentless campaigns on various issues ignoring even his advancing age

during his term as leader of the Opposition from 2001 to 2006. Au contraire, Vijayan, gradually acquired a villain's image in media and the public mind. The images have only been reinforced since LDF came to power in May last year.

Last week, the relations between the two hit a nadir when Kairali, the CPI(M)-owned Malayalam television channel controlled by Vijayan, telecast an interview with a controversial local businessman, Pharis Aboobacker. There were several things intriguing about the interview, not the least of which was that it went on for a whole two hours. The reason was simple: Aboobacker said things that were



Though his rivals control the state party unit, Achuthanandan's popular image ensures threats are nipped

music to the Vijayan faction's ears. At one point, he even said Achuthanandan had contacted him in the run-up to the last assembly elections, though he did not specify what had transpired during their conversation. The intention was clearly to mar the chief minister's squeaky clean image and show him as one with the same failings as most other politicians. The chief minister was livid and was said to have retorted that he was "not a low life as to even talk to someone as reviled as

Aboobacker". The businessman was a defendant in a multimillion dollar scam related to the National Kidney Foundation in Singapore and was also an associate of T.T. Durai, former CEO of the foundation, who is currently facing trial there.

Of late, not a single day goes by without yet another skeleton tumbling out of Vijayan faction's cupboard. Nothing has been more embarrassing for the state secretary than the party central leadership's decision to initiate action against his close associate, E.P. Jayarajan, a member of the CPI(M) Central Committee and also the general manager of the party mouth-piece *Deshabhimani*. The newspaper is alleged to have received Rs 2 crore as a "special deposit" from Santiago Martin, a Chennai-based businessman and lottery tycoon who is on the run and against whom arrest warrants have been issued.

The party tried several figleaves as a cover-up—initially, it said it was a "loan", later it was turned into a "deposit" and, finally into a "bond". When the heat from the media became unbearable, the party said it would return the money, only to invite taunts from Opposition parties which sought to know to whom the money would be returned, as the "donor" was absconding.

Jayarajan was stripped of his managerial responsibilities with the newspaper. In a statement, the party admitted that it was wrong for it to have accepted money from the controversial tycoon. A few weeks earlier, a deputy general manager in the same newspaper, who was also a Vijayan acolyte, was sacked after it was found that he had accepted a bribe of Rs 1 crore. These scandals surfaced shortly after a Comptroller and Auditor General report had found irregularities in the Lavlin case—the granting of Rs 350-crore contract to a Canadian firm for renovation of three power generation plants during Vijayan's tenure as the power minister in the last CPI(M)-led government between 1996 and 2001.

Vijayan's image as a man of mystery was reinforced when a few months ago, security personnel at Chennai airport recovered bullets from his handbag. He did have a licence for a revolver, but was cheeky enough to think he could carry it into an aircraft. ■